

IMPACT REPORT



COOL/ SCARY AI SH!T

Brooklyn Summit · 2025

FROM THE ORGANIZING TEAM

Hello,

Thank you for being part of our Brooklyn gathering of Cool/Scary AI Sh!t — or for cheering us on from nearby. We are sending you the session summaries and a short synthesis to make the ideas easy to share across your team. Our goal is simple: help mission-driven organizations turn curiosity into responsible, measurable action.

Across the day, four themes stood out. Culture beats tools: the organizations making real progress pair leadership sponsorship with enterprise literacy, clear policies, and psychologically safe spaces to experiment. Data foundations and guardrails matter: start small, but make your integrations explicit and your ethics, security and privacy visible. Practical automation wins: unsexy use cases free capacity you can reinvest in higher-value work. And experience drives ROI.

We also surfaced useful tensions — shipping fast versus aligning the enterprise, good-enough data versus prerequisites, agent hype versus durable systems, and near-term lift versus long-term trust. Naming these contradictions helps teams choose deliberately rather than by default.

How to use this packet: share the summaries with colleagues, pick one pilot you can launch in the next two weeks, and adopt a lightweight decision log to document what you tried, what changed, and why.

Thanks again for showing up, sharing candidly, and building this community with us. We look forward to seeing what you ship next.

Onward,

Ben Childers and Partners

Cool/Scary AI Sh!t Organizing Team



WHAT BROOKLYN CONVERGED ON

Across eight sessions, speakers converged on a pragmatic, culture-first approach to AI in the social-impact sector.

They showed quick wins from unsexy automation — email triage, SMS onboarding, meeting-to-project-management actions, topic-page blurbs — and rapid prototyping of vibe-coded apps, while emphasizing foundations: governance, ethics, data security and staff readiness.

Performance gains come from reducing donor friction and pairing large language models with classic data science to find the real content drivers. Tension points surfaced throughout — speed versus alignment, imperfect data versus prerequisites, flashy agents versus durable systems, short-term conversion optimization versus mission-aligned virtues — pushing organizations to blend experimentation with guardrails.

MAIN TAKEAWAY

Treat AI as an organizational capability, not a tool. Start with shared literacy and governance, define clear guardrails, and run small, well-scoped pilots that you measure and iterate. Connect systems early, publish what changes and why, and prioritize supporter experience — guided by adaptive ethics. Move fast on prototypes, but earn scale through trust, alignment and documented learning.

“The goal isn’t faster copy; it’s trust, alignment, and clarity that scales change.”

ON CULTURE-FIRST ADOPTION



CONTRADICTIONS

Naming the tensions helps teams choose deliberately rather than by default.

Ship fast vs. go slow

Peskey and Snyder vibe-code live apps in minutes and Sacdalan automates 90-day SMS flows, prioritizing momentum. Trzop and Kimber/Pogoff argue for deliberate pacing: governance first, policy as a living garden, cautious enterprise alignment. Perez shows the reality — crises force speed, but approvals stretch months.

Agents disappoint vs. no-code impresses

Alani says LLM-only agents underperform without classic data science. Peskey and Snyder wow with rapid, no-code application building. Developers may later reject AI-generated code as unmaintainable — raising questions about longevity, handoff and technical debt.

Good-enough data vs. prerequisites

Kimber/Pogoff and Trzop caution against perfectionism: start small, do not wait for pristine hygiene. Alani insists the upside appears only after platform integration and modeling; Peskey warns that productionizing vibe-coded tools without secure data practices is risky.

Conversion vs. mission virtues

Salpietro pushes e-commerce-style personalization and aggressive conversion optimization to lift revenue. Childers' adaptive-ethics model would reject suppressing low-income ZIP codes despite better returns. Optimize ruthlessly for short-term lift, or constrain tactics to protect equity, dignity and long-term trust.



PATTERNS

What held across every session, regardless of the speaker's subject.

Culture-first adoption

Successful organizations pair active executive sponsorship with cross-functional AI governance, enterprise AI-101 literacy, and psychologically safe play spaces that include skeptics. Teams use a shared ethics, data, security and privacy lens, treat policy as a living garden, and document decisions.

Practical automation beats flashy demos

The biggest wins came from unsexy work: email triage and routing, 90-day SMS onboarding, meeting-to-project actions, topic-page toppers, lightweight agenda apps. Small pilots with feedback loops, decision logs and monitoring checkpoints earn the next investment. Analytics become triggers, not reports.

Foundations and guardrails before scale

Connect systems, do not chase perfect hygiene, and wrap AI in explicit guardrails. Adaptive ethics informs boundaries; security and privacy drive choices like stateless prototypes and keeping sensitive data out of vibe-coded apps. Classify unstructured content, add QA loops, monitor drift.

Experience and ROI through personalization

Optimize supporter experience to drive measurable lift. Borrow e-commerce playbooks — address autocomplete, modern payments, abandoned-donation reminders — then layer AI-driven personalization. Pair LLMs with classic modeling to find true content drivers, and test where gains could be ten to twenty percent rather than half of one.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS

Eight speakers, from deeply technical insight to community-driven storytelling, each illuminating a different facet of engaging with AI responsibly.

Tareq Alani

CHORUS AI

Explains why LLM-only agents underperform and shows how pairing them with classic data science unlocks real marketing gains. He outlines a pipeline — integrate platforms, classify unstructured content via vectors, model drivers with regressions and forests, then continuously optimize with automated QA and a coaching bank. Early pilots show ten to twenty percent engagement lifts and half the content-production time saved.

Jamie Perez

CENTER FOR AMERICAN PROGRESS

Shares a pragmatic generative AI project: auto-writing topper blurbs for 177 website topic pages amid nonstop crisis work. The system drafted 115; editors deemed 40 viable and published 14 — break-even so far, results pending. The deeper win is culture: treating analytics as triggers, building trust in AI-assisted text, and iterating recursively.



Pam Trzop

FIREFLY PARTNERS

Argues AI is not just a tool but organization-wide process augmentation. Adoption succeeds when leadership actively sponsors change, cross-functional workgroups set policy, data ethics and integration are clear, and teams are trained with trust and governance. ROI is alignment, clarity and better supporter experiences — not just faster content. Start small; avoid perfectionism.



Joshua Peskey with Kim Snyder

VIBE CODING

Demonstrates spinning up a board-meeting agenda app live from audience prompts. He outlines best uses — prototypes, internal dashboards, stateless tools — and the risks: security, sensitive data, production handoff. A prebuilt demo shows guardrails and features including branding, drag-and-drop, PDF export and hosting.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS, CONTINUED

Ben Childers

STRATOVATION PARTNERS

Urges a shift from bureaucratic checklists to adaptive, virtue-based ethics for digital transformation. His loop: anticipate context, set guardrails, pilot small experiments, learn and publish changes, articulate virtues. The worked example rejects suppressing low-income ZIP codes to boost returns, adding an equity guardrail instead. Start small — choose virtues, keep a decision log, set two guardrails, add monitoring.

Maan Sacdalan

STRATOVATION PARTNERS

Shows how AI-driven workflows streamline nonprofit operations: email triage and sentiment routing, 90-day SMS onboarding, a 40-day welcome and fully automated year-end campaign, content repurposing, and meeting-to-project actions. She stresses QA, avoiding over-automation, and change management. Results included a 41% open rate on year-end emails — time saved, but new expectations, so keep humans in the loop.

Sal Salpietro

FUNDRAISE UP

Argues intentions are not enough — experience wins. Using a Sicily trip as metaphor, he shows how dated, friction-heavy donor journeys depress conversion: no receipts, no address autocomplete, limited payment options. Borrow e-commerce playbooks to remove friction, lift average gifts, and meet mobile expectations. The scary future is not adapting.

Rachel Kimber and Samin Pogoff

ENTERPRISE AI LITERACY

Argue that AI 101 is essential enterprise-wide: start with governance across AI and data, shared language, and psychologically safe play, then move quickly to policy and change management. Center ethics, data, security and privacy; align leaders and doers; pilot one use case; measure and iterate. Treat policy as a living garden, include skeptics — culture beats tools.



WITH THANKS

THANK YOU TO OUR SPONSORS



FUNDRAISE UP



CHORUS AI



STRATOVATION
PARTNERS

COOL/SCARY AI

A national series of community-centered
conversations about AI's real impact,
produced by Stratovation Partners.

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